

Setting Up a GitHub Account

A complete guide for LSE students using your institutional email

GitHub is a cloud platform for hosting and version-controlling code with Git, widely used for coursework, group projects, dissertations and job applications in tech-related fields. A GitHub account is free, and sign-up takes about five minutes.

Before you start: which email should you use?

You can sign up to GitHub with any email address, including your LSE email (@lse.ac.uk) or a personal one (e.g. Gmail). Both work equally well for the sign-up itself, but consider the following before choosing:

- Use your LSE email if you plan to apply for the GitHub Student Developer Pack (see Section 5) — school email is the fastest verification route, and lse.ac.uk is generally recognised as a valid academic domain.
- Your LSE email will typically be deactivated some time after you graduate or leave LSE, which can complicate signing back in and can cause you to lose access to a Student Developer Pack tied to it. Add a personal email as a backup (Section 6) so you are not locked out later.

Assumption: This guide assumes you are signing up with your LSE email. If you later decide to switch to a personal email as your primary contact, you can do this from Settings → Emails once your account exists — see Section 6.

Step 1: Go to the GitHub sign-up page

1. Open your browser and navigate to github.com/signup.
2. You can also click “Sign up” from the top-right of the GitHub homepage (github.com) if you prefer to start there.

Step 2: Enter your details

1. Email address: enter your LSE email, e.g. your username @lse.ac.uk.
2. Create a password and do not reuse it from your LSE IT Services login.
3. Username: choose a username, which will form part of your public profile URL (github.com/yourusername) and is often seen by recruiters and collaborators. A short, professional handle (e.g. based on your name) tends to work better than a nickname.

Step 3: Complete verification and confirm your email

1. Solve the verification puzzle when prompted, following the on-screen instructions. If it fails to load, temporarily disable any ad-blocking browser extension and refresh the page.
2. Click Create account.

3. GitHub sends a launch code to the email address you entered. Check your LSE inbox (and your Junk/Spam folder — institutional spam filters occasionally flag automated GitHub emails) and enter the code on the GitHub page.

Step 4: Set your preferences and choose a plan

1. GitHub will ask a few optional questions (e.g. team size, areas of interest) to tailor your experience; skip them if possible.
2. On the plan screen, select the Free plan (labelled something like “Continue for free”). This gives unlimited public and private repositories, which is all students normally need — do not enter payment details.
3. You will land on your new GitHub dashboard. Your account is now active.

Step 5: Claim the GitHub Student Developer Pack (optional but recommended)

The [Student Developer Pack](#) unlocks free tools, including GitHub Pro features, cloud credits, and professional IDE licences, once you prove student status. Note: As of 2026, GitHub has temporarily paused new sign-ups for the free Copilot Student plan specifically; students who verify now still receive the rest of the pack and get Copilot Free in the meantime.

1. Go to education.github.com/pack while signed in to your new GitHub account.
2. Click “Get student benefits” (or “Start an application”) and select Student as your role.
3. When asked to verify, choose school email verification and enter your LSE email if it was not already your account email. Then, GitHub will send a confirmation link to it.
4. Approval is usually automatic or within about 72 hours. You'll receive an email once your student benefits are active.

Step 6: Secure your account and add a backup email

1. Go to Settings → Password and authentication and turn on two-factor authentication (2FA). You can use an authenticator app (e.g., Microsoft Authenticator, Google Authenticator, or Apple Passwords), which is more reliable than SMS.
2. Go to Settings → Emails and add a personal email address (e.g. a Gmail account) as a backup, in case your LSE email is deactivated after you leave LSE.
3. Consider setting your personal email as the primary email later (Settings → Emails → make primary) once your account and any Student Pack benefits are established, so you retain access long-term. Re-verify the Student Pack against a personal email or document proof before your LSE email is switched off, if you want to keep using education benefits.
4. Download your account recovery codes from Settings → Password and authentication and store them somewhere safe (not only in your LSE email).

Troubleshooting

Symptom	What to do
Verification email never arrives	Check Junk/Spam. Use “Resend” rather than re-signing up. If it still fails, try again with a personal email and add the LSE email afterwards under Settings → Emails.
Student Developer Pack rejects the lse.ac.uk domain	Switch to document verification: upload a clear photo of your student ID or an enrolment letter that shows the current academic year and your name.
Copilot isn't included after Student Pack approval	Expected as of the 2026 pause on new free Copilot Student sign-ups — you'll have Copilot Free instead. Check GitHub's education pack page for the current status, as this may change.
Locked out after LSE email was deactivated	Use the backup personal email and recovery codes from Section 6. If neither was set up in advance, use GitHub's account recovery form, which can take longer and may require proof of identity.

Need further help? GitHub Support: support.github.com. For Student Developer Pack verification issues specifically, use the contact link on education.github.com/pack.